# A GROWING PIGEON MENACE

By **DHAVAL S. KULKARNI**

**The humble pigeon has fluttered through human history**—as messenger, companion and cultural symbol. Bollywood even immortalised the ubiquitous bird as an emblem of love in the 1989 romantic blockbuster *Maine Pyar Kiya*. But in today's urban India, the bird has become an object of ambivalence—evoking compassion in some and seen by others as a harbinger of disease and civic decay.

Mumbai is witnessing such tensions of late. On November 3, Jain monk Nileshchandra Vijay launched a protest at Azad Maidan against the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation's (BMC) decision to shut down the iconic *kabutarkhana* in Dadar, one of the city's largest pigeon-feeding sites. For the Jain community, feeding pigeons is a pious act. Earlier, the monk had warned that the community would "take up arms" against the crackdown.

Meanwhile, the BMC's move to permit controlled pigeon feeding at four new locations has drawn protests from residents of Lokhandwala, Andheri. They fear that large-scale feeding could drive away the 100-odd migratory and exotic bird species that frequent the Lokhandwala lake. Earlier, a proposal by the state government to set up feeding centres in areas such as the Sanjay Gandhi National Park was opposed by wildlife conservationist Kedar Gore, who cautioned that these sites would attract other species along with pigeons, exposing them to the zoonotic diseases the birds carry.

The conflict first began sometime in July, when Maharashtra's legislature debated the health risks of pigeon droppings at 51 feeding sites across Mumbai. Industries minister Uday Samant said the BMC would be asked to shut them down. Animal rights activists rushed to the Bombay High Court, which, in an interim order, ruled that "human health was paramount", but halted demolition of the feeding stations. In August, when the BMC covered the sites with tarpaulin sheets to prevent feeding, the feeders resisted. Hundreds of them stormed the Dadar *kabutarkhana* and tore down the sheets. Around 50,000 pigeons were sustained there on roughly 1,500 kg of grain daily, offered mainly by members of the Jain community. The protesters defied police orders and sparked sectarian unease in India's financial capital.

The issue is not unique to Mumbai. Pigeons are testing civic patience across the country. Delhi's municipal body is weighing



## AVIAN AILMENTS

***With growing concerns over pigeons causing illnesses, Dr Amit Sakaria, senior consultant physician at Ruby Hall Clinic, Pune, lists some of the serious diseases caused by pigeon exposure***

↘ **Histoplasmosis:** **Caused by fungi like *Histoplasma capsulatum* found in pigeon droppings; can lead to serious lung complications**